

# Crunch time on defense spending

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## 【要点】

- ・ EU指導者たちが防衛支出の増加方法について協議しており、敵対勢力からの脅威の増加とトランプ大統領の計画に対する不確実性を背景に、資金確保が急務となっている。
- ・ ドイツのメルツ首相がバルト三国の指導者と会談し、NATO首脳会談（アンカラ）を前にウクライナ支援を含む欧州の安全保障について議論する。
- ・ NATOの大多数の加盟国が2035年までにGDPの5%を防衛費に充てることを約束しているが、より早期の達成を求める国もある。
- ・ 欧州はより強力な防衛責任を担うことで、トランプ政権との関係修復を図るためNATO首脳会談で防衛投資への取り組みをアピールする予定である。

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## 【メール原文】

POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MOR

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GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin, coming to you the morning after POLITICO's staff summer party. Bon courage to my colleagues getting up early to cover Coreper I and a string of working parties slated for this morning.

In today's Playbook:

- Liberals call for scaled-back veto powers and gear up for centrist soul-searching.
- From art fairs to the Ommegang parade: your Brussels weekend is covered.
- Faces in the crowd: Kaja Kallas, Lukas Sieper, Svenja Hahn, Kristen Michal, Holy Roman Emperor Charles V, Cillian Murphy, Marine Le Pen and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender podcast: Anne McElvoy has the latest from POLITICO's Victor Jack on the NATO summit preparations and Peter Snowdon talks to Estonian Defence Minister Hanno Pevkur on healing the EU-U.S. relationship.

DRIVING THE DAY

**DEFENSE SPENDING DRIVE:** EU leaders are sitting down for talks on how quickly they can boost defense spending, amid growing threats from hostile powers and increasing uncertainty over President Donald Trump's plans. But the clock is ticking to work out how to pay for it.

**Frontline warning:** German Chancellor Friedrich Merz will today meet the leaders of Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania to discuss European security and support for Ukraine, ahead of next week's NATO summit in Ankara. All NATO countries apart from Spain have committed themselves to spending 5 percent of their GDP on defense by 2035 — but some want that to be done far sooner.

**Not if, but when:** "The question is no longer whether Europe should do more for its own security. The question is how quickly we can deliver. A stronger Europe means a stronger NATO," Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal told Playbook ahead of the meeting.

**A stitch in time:** "Investing in deterrence today is far less expensive than paying for the consequences of aggression tomorrow. The message from Ankara must be clear: Europe is ready to take greater responsibility for its own security while keeping the transatlantic alliance strong," Michal said.

**It's all about the money:** Spending commitments will be on show next week, with NATO allies hoping to use the summit to repair relations with Trump. The friendship was strained after Europeans hesitated in joining U.S. attacks on Iran, with Washington announcing plans to withdraw troops and capabilities from Europe.

**Hey, big spenders:** Leaders will be trumpeting the extra €139 billion NATO members (excluding the U.S.) spent this year on defense. Their commitment is to shoulder the burden of defending the continent and — according to a person familiar with the planning who spoke to my colleague Victor Jack — announce "double digit" billions in new procurement deals.

**Keep it snappy:** There's just one three-hour session planned, in a bid to keep Trump from getting bored, one NATO official told POLITICO. Although keeping the U.S. president engaged might not be a problem, if his overnight social media post lamenting the size of American NATO spending is anything to go by.

**Canada's middle-power posse:** Reuters is reporting that Ottawa hopes to use next week's summit to announce about 10 founding countries for a global defense bank, as part of Prime Minister Mark Carney's call for an alliance of middle powers. So far, only Luxembourg has publicly joined the initiative.

**Finding the money:** Boosting European defense capabilities depends on new funding in the EU's long-term budget, the MFF, which is at the center of a fierce battle between net payers and net recipients. "The money that is supposed to be dedicated to defense is much greater than in the previous MFF," said one EU official of the draft plans. But "we need to find the means to do it, and we need new 'own resources' to pay for this," the official said.

**Problematic:** The size of the spending and the new powers the EU wants to raise the money are still proving controversial for capitals.

**Buckle up:** The twin issues of protecting Europe and signing off on the MFF will dominate the agenda for the rest of the year. Officials told Playbook that October's European Council will focus on the debate. The summit is expected to last for two days — a rare move for Council President António Costa, who has championed efficient one-day affairs that spare leaders, diplomats (and reporters) brutal back-to-back negotiations.

**\*\*NATO leaders head to Ankara at a make-or-break moment for the alliance. Join POLITICO reporters from Brussels, Washington and London for an online briefing on July 6 for a preview of the summit's biggest flashpoints, from Ukraine and Iran to U.S. troop withdrawals and transatlantic tensions. Register now .\*\***

## BIG AND BREAKING

**TAKING ACTION:** Top EU diplomat Kaja Kallas has proposed a new round of sanctions on Russia's military industries , following the recent deadly attack on Ukraine that killed at least 27 people, according to recent reports .

**BEIJING CRACKDOWN:** The EU is setting a deadline of October to outline its response to unfair Chinese trade practices, trade chief Maroš Šefčovič has told ambassadors, with officials working through the summer on the proposals. More for subscribers in Morning Trade .

**JUDGMENT DAY:** French far-right leader Marine Le Pen is set to find out on Tuesday whether she'll be able to stand as a candidate in next year's presidential elections, after a long-running legal battle over an embezzlement complaint.

## DASHBOARD

**WHO CAN WE DEPEND ON?** Europeans want to rely on themselves to defend their countries — but they want to see proof it's possible, according to polling data shared with POLITICO.

## LIBERALS VS. VETO

**NO BLOCKERS:** The EU's liberal party ALDE is calling on the bloc's institutions to curtail the power of national governments to veto foreign policy. ALDE is calling for a "pooled veto," under which only groups of five EU members, representing at least 5 percent of the bloc's population, could block decisions.

The proposal follows the angst sparked by former Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán's hostility to the EU's Ukraine policy. It's also designed to allay concerns over veto powers, which may be slowing down EU enlargement, starting from the accession of Montenegro.

**Vienna bash:** The policy suggestion is part of a resolution, obtained by POLITICO, to be debated and voted on by hundreds of delegates gathering in Vienna today for ALDE's annual congress. They include representatives from Dutch party D66, Estonia's Reform Party and Romania's USR.

**Broad range of proposals:** The parties — including 12 in government across the EU — will seek to agree on 17 resolutions, ranging from the economy to social media bans and Ukraine. We scooped them for you .

**Tough times:** The gathering comes at a difficult moment for Europe's liberals, two years after the 2024 EU elections. As the European People's Party increasingly relies on far-right votes and the Socialists & Democrats pull left, the liberals' Renew Europe grouping — which is a broadly centrist and socially progressive — is witnessing its internal factions drifting further apart.

Migration: Those tensions were laid bare during the vote on the EU's return regulation: 37 Renew MEPs were in favor of the measures; 21 against; and 12 abstained. These divisions are likely to resurface this weekend as delegates debate a migration resolution calling for trade sanctions against countries refusing to readmit deported nationals.

Belgian surprise: The clearest illustration of the widening gaps among Europe's liberals is Belgium's Georges-Louis Bouchez. The Reformist Movement leader recently suggested his party could one day join the EPP, arguing that Renew has become too cautious on the need for economic reform. Bouchez canceled his trip to Vienna two days before the congress.

We get it: "I understand that [Bouchez] is concerned about some economic positions," said German MEP Svenja Hahn, ALDE's president, who is set to be re-elected unopposed on Saturday. Hahn is among the liberals pushing for sweeping deregulation as part of the EU's omnibus packages — although others in the party believe that goes too far. "We'd need a German Autobahn with no speed limit for the omnibuses to move forward significantly faster," Hahn joked.

## 20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The European Parliament's energy committee on Thursday discussed its position on elements of the EU's plans to strengthen the bloc's energy plan. But what is the European Grids Package? It's a plan to modernize and expand Europe's electricity infrastructure, in part because some 40 percent of distribution grids are over 40 years old. It includes common EU-wide grid planning, expanded cross-border infrastructure rules and faster procedures for granting permits. Talks among the main EU institutions on the package will take place later this year.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

## POSTCARD FROM IRELAND

COLLEGE DAZE: Day 2 of the College of Commissioners' visit to Ireland to mark the start of the country's rotating presidency was hosted at University College Cork. The institution has an impressive list of alumni, from Taoiseach Micheál Martin to actor Cillian Murphy (who attended but never graduated).

Circle of life: Commission Deputy Chief Spokesperson Olof Gill is an old boy of the college, telling Playbook's Gerardo Fortuna on the ground that he was "delighted and proud" to be back on campus, having finished his degree during Ireland's 2004 Council presidency. "It feels like coming full circle."

On the menu: Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and her team last night feasted on Ballycotton Seafood, mushrooms and summer berries, with Roscommon chargrilled beef fillet and fondant with potatoes, and a light Jameson Irish Whiskey cream.

What's on today: Expect thematic sessions between commissioners and Irish ministers, with competitiveness and security topping the agenda, alongside a plenary meeting between the Commission and government.

The unavoidable MFF: Martin made clear what would consume Ireland's presidency: The budget negotiations ahead would be "very, very tough," he warned. In his words: "Budget is reconciling the irreconcilable." His target date is the special European Council on November 26, when leaders will try to bridge the gap between frugals, friends of cohesion and everyone in between.

## 5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

ROYAL ROMANCE RISKS ELECTORAL GUILLOTINE: Jordan Bardella's romance with an Italian princess is clashing with his working class credentials, the French far-right leader's allies fear.

NUCLEAR RETHINK: Lithuanian President Gitanas Nausėda says his country is close to scrapping its historic prohibition on nuclear weapons, raising the prospect of hosting American warheads.

HOW TO DEAL WITH TRUMP: MAGA-friendly Greece should follow in Spain's footsteps and burn its bridges with Washington, former left-wing Prime Minister Alexis Tsipras told POLITICO in an interview.

A BIG SPLASH: In this week's Declassified column, Paul Dallison looks at the French far-right's new enemy: a teenage boy armed with a water pistol.

TROUBLED WATERS: A shipyard in Denmark is racing to service Russia's icebreaking gas tankers, which help fuel the Kremlin's war in Ukraine, before a ban comes in at the end of the year.

## BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mainly sunny, top of 24C.

NEAR MISS: This week's Russian missile attacks on Ukraine hit a hotel where Parliament staff had been staying earlier in the week, President Roberta Metsola has revealed, with one hitting what had been a staffer's room, according to MEP Lukas Sieper. "If anyone needed any further proof why Europe cannot back down on Ukraine, there you have it," Sieper said.

PARLIAMENT'S BIGGEST FOOTBALL FAN: Turn left when you step out onto the 13th floor of Parliament's E Tower and you'll see a shrine to football. The display's architect is Andrzej Halicki, head of the EPP's Polish delegation and Prime Minister Donald Tusk's point man in the Parliament. The hallway in front of Halicki's office is lined with photos of the MEP on the pitch and snapshots of players celebrating victories — all centered around a foosball table.

The beautiful parliamentary game: Colleagues have been handed footballs with Halicki's name and bearing the motto "Team EPP," while World Cup knockout brackets decorate the walls so visitors can track the tournament all the way to the final.

OUR WEEKEND SUGGESTIONS: Congratulations on making it through another busy week! Here's how you can switch off a little before it's time to do it all again.

Take in some nighttime art ... The Bozar museum, the Fine Arts museum and the Royal Library of Belgium — all located around Mont des Arts — have organized Arts at Night, with single ticket giving you access to exhibitions, music and sunset views from their rooftops.

... or some daytime art: Ixelles is hosting the Nayad street-art festival this weekend, starting today, with circus acts, theater and music on the program.

Some local folklore ... As part of the annual Ommegang parade, over 1,000 participants in festive costumes will re-imagine the 1549 Brussels arrival of Holy Roman Emperor Charles V and his son Philip II. At the time, the city was the power center of the Habsburg Netherlands. Catch it today.

... or some jazz: Why not enjoy the sun at the Brosella Festival in the Osseghem park, next to the Atomium? It's running for three days, starting today, and this is where you can get tickets.

A royal visit: The Royal Palace of Brussels, just a stone's throw from the EU institutions, is the Belgian king's administrative HQ — and it's open to visitors from today until mid-August. Book a slot first, though .

## TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: AfD delegates will gather in Erfurt this weekend for a tense federal party conference , amid growing dissatisfaction with the far-right party's leadership.

London: Prime Minister-in-waiting Andy Burnham has promised to answer "anything" on social media today, after a fortnight of avoiding difficult questions .

Paris: Marine Le Pen and Jordan Bardella will appear together one last time ahead of a court decision that will shape the National Rally's presidential election campaign.

Washington PM: Weak job growth is denying Republicans the boost they had hoped for , just four months out from the November midterm elections.

## AGENDA

— Latvian Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs, Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal and Lithuanian President Gitanas Nausėda meet German Chancellor Friedrich Merz in Berlin.

— European Council President António Costa talks with ECB President Christine Lagarde on a stage in southern France, as part of the Rencontres économiques conference .

— Coreper I meets at 10 a.m.

— College of Commissioners visit Cork.

— Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica meets Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty in Cairo.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in a fireside chat with EDAM Chair Sinan Ülgen in Istanbul, Turkey. Follow here .

## BIRTHDAYS

Former European Parliament Secretary-General Klaus Welle; MEPs Mathilde Androuët and Esther Herranz García; former Polish Prime Minister Leszek Miller; former President of the European Parliament Jerzy Buzek; former MEPs Bernard Monot and Lieve Wierinck; CEFIC's Marco Mensink; EISMEA's Luiza Heidelk; WikiLeaks founder Julian Assange. Belarus Independence Day.

Celebrating Saturday: MEPs Eero Heinäluoma and Gilles Boyer; former European Commissioner Phil Hogan; Albanian Prime Minister Edi Rama; Horst Seehofer, former Bavarian premier and POLITICO 28 alum; freelance journalist Ana Fota; Cool Heating Coalition's Tom Vasseur; POLITICO's Jonas Loesel. U.S. Independence Day.

Celebrating Sunday: Former MEP Jan Huitema; former MEP, former Slovenian PM and ace harmonica player Alojz Peterle.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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